The question may still be asked, "How can we know that a particular authority is right?" We must know it to be right before we can believe in it. Of course, you must know it to be right before you believe it. This is exactly what is meant by the reliability of "word." That one relies upon authority does not mean that one is called upon to believe in unverified or unverifiable authority. No one maintains that testimony or authority is above verifiability, which is again a common ground between authority and all other sources of knowledge. Authority is rejected when it no longer proves to be true. As Vasiṣṭha, one of the most revered and acknowledged authorities in Indian philosophy, says: "A reasonable statement, even of a child, should be accepted, while the unreasonable ones are to be discarded like straw, even though they are made by the Creator Himself. A devotee of Reason should value the words even of ordinary persons, provided they advance knowledge and are logical, and should throw away those of sages, if they are not such."[1] Testimony in philosophy is believed to be already tested and verified exactly as in the case of road signs. No one gets out of his car in order to see whether the bridge is really narrow after reading the sign "narrow bridge ahead." You first believe in your road signs (or in the words of the doctor) and that provides an opportunity for the test or verification of the truth or the falsity of the testimony. Verifiability itself would not be possible if one did not admit these signs and words as valid *sources* of knowledge to begin with. While verifiability tests the truth or falsity of knowledge, it does not produce it. What is contended here is that knowledge should first be admitted for the time being as true on testimony before you can verify and accept or reject it as true or false. The validity of belief in authority lies solely and exclusively in its reliability. And it is this reliability of the word of another that is recognized as an independent valid source of knowledge in Indian philosophy. This reliability is based entirely upon verifiability. No orthodox Indian system of philosophy says that the words of the Vedas may be false and yet you should believe in them. The orthodox systems only say that they have been established as true and are hence reliable. If you can prove that they are false, they will not be reliable and hence will not constitute authority. But this will be a disbelief only in the Vedas, i.e., the authoritativeness of a particular testimony, but not disbelief in authority itself as a valid means of knowledge.

Now, what is such a valid means of knowledge that finds such an important place in philosophical discussions in orthodox schools of Indian philosophy? Questions relating to the origin and the validity of knowledge are the core of philosophical discussion, and,